

ON TECHNIQUE

Cutting corners

Urged on by impatient theater promoters, Rossini was constantly pushed to work at a furious pace. In order to meet their punishing schedules, the composer took a number of shortcuts. He reused some overtures—the overture to *The Barber of Seville*, for example, had already featured in two of his earlier operas (*Elizabeth, Queen of England* and *Aureliano*). Rossini also adopted the practice of using *arie di baule* (luggage arias)—individual arias borrowed from other operas, even if they were irrelevant to the plot. Similarly, he farmed out some less significant sections to other composers, including Giovanni Tadolini. Rossini outsourced much of the recitative of *Cinderella*, as well as reusing earlier arias, in order to get the opera ready in time for the Christmas season.

Gioachino Rossini was born in Pesaro, on the northeastern coast of Italy. His parents were professional musicians: his father held the post of town trumpeter and played the horn in a local orchestra; his mother was a singer. Under their influence, Gioachino developed musical skills at a very early age. He had already started composing by the time he entered the liceo musicale (music college) in Bologna at the age of just 14.

Early career

Before his voice broke, Rossini earned some money singing in churches and theaters, although composition remained his chief focus. By 1810, he had completed his first two-act operatic score, *Demetrio e Polibio* (premiered 1812). Later in 1810, he achieved the first public staging of one of his operas—*La cambiale di matrimonio* (The